LESSON 5: DIMENSIONS OF CURRICULUM

5.1 Introduction

Welcome to our fifth lesson. In our last lesson, we discussed about curriculum aims, goals and objectives. In this lesson we shall discuss on the dimensions of curriculum. Before we continue, lets ask ourselves what is a dimension? In general definition, a dimension is a measurable extent of a particular kind, such as length, breadth, depth, or height. It is an aspect or feature of a situation. If you talk about the dimensions of an object or place, you are referring to its size and proportions. A dimension is a measurement such as length, width, or height. Taking from these definitions of dimension, curriculum too has dimensions or measurements which lead to learning.

A dimension of learning is a comprehensive model that uses what researchers and theorists know about learning to define the learning process. Its premise is that type of thinking, what we call the dimensions of learning, are essential to successful learning. Whereas the three elements of a school curriculum may be identified as curriculum objectives, learning activities and students' assessment, the four types of school dimensions curriculum may be stated as formal, non-formal, informal and emerging dimensions. It is important to note that different scholars have come up with different aspects of what they refer to as the dimensions of curriculum however, they all agree on the inclusion of the above four dimensions of curriculum.

5.2 Lesson learning outcomes

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

5.2.1 Define formal dimension or curriculum

5.2.2 Describe the Non-Formal Dimension

5.2.3 Explain the meaning of Informal Dimension

5.2.4 Explain the meaning of Emerging Dimension

5.2.5 Describe the Curriculum dimensions in the 21st century teaching & learning

5.2.1 Formal Dimension of curriculum

The formal dimension curriculum refers to that aspect of the school curriculum which consists of those learning activities that students undertake formally as a class as well as the curriculum objectives and students' assessment methods that relate to them. The formal dimension of curriculum refers to education carried out in institutions, with specific goals and a well stated curriculum, venues, well defined teachers and learners. It is the process of training and developing people in knowledge, skills, mind, and character in a structured and certified program. The activities in the formal dimension of curriculum may be carried out inside or outside classrooms, or even outside the school compound, but they are normally undertaken by students as formal class work. These activities are normally embodied in what is known as courses of students in a school, showing the objectives to be achieved at and the way in which the students would be assessed. Having discussed the formal dimension, lets not shift focus to the non-formal dimension of curriculum.

5.2.2 Non-Formal Dimension

Non-formal dimension of curriculum refers to those learning activities that were traditionally referred to as extra-curricular and more recently as co-curricular activities. The terminology is based on the way these activities are organized. As we know, they are organized in a less rigid manner than the formal learning activities. For example, they are not carried out by students in the regular class groupings, rather students group themselves in accordance with such factors as individual interest, attitudes and ages. As was said earlier these learning activities may be carried out inside or outside the classroom, or inside or outside the school compound. It is any organized systematic educational activity carried on outside the framework of the formal system to provide selected types of learning.

5.2.3 Informal Dimension

The informal dimensions of curriculum consist of the guided aspects of the informal learning activities that go in a school all the time. Examples of the guided informal learning activities would be the interaction with the planned aspects of the school environment; for instance, the assimilation of desirable habits by students from good examples deliberately given by the staff of a school. The informal dimension of curriculum is the unstructured education where learning takes place through imitation, observation and participation. It is the life-long

process by which every person acquires and accumulates knowledge, skills, attitudes and insights etc from daily experience and exposure to the environment at, home, school, at work at pay. It is generally unorganized and often unsystematic. The activities include attitude, habits, hidden values, often copied from teachers, elders and teens. Informal interaction goes on all the time, but not all the interactions form desirable learning activities.

The informal dimension consists of all that is learned during school activities, out of the designated official curriculum. These includes:

- How learners should sit
- How to greet the teacher how to attend to a visitor in the school
- Role of the teacher and prefect
- How to relate with the teachers, fellow students and other people at school.
- How learners learn values such as hard work, respect, obedience, co-operation, value for others, empathy etc.

5.2.4 Emerging Dimension

According to Wikipedia, Emergent curriculum is a philosophy of teaching and a way of planning a children's curriculum that focuses on being responsive to their interests. The goal is to create meaningful learning experiences for the children. The emerging dimension of curriculum includes such activities as tree planting, entertainment, national celebrations, prize giving days, and parent days. The dimension prioritizes active participation by students, relationship-building among students, flexible and adaptable methods, inquiry by students and play-based learning by students. Emergent curriculum is child-initiated, collaborative and responsive to the children's needs. Proponents state that knowledge of the children is the key to success in any emergent curriculum

5.2.5 Curriculum dimensions in the 21st century teaching & learning

Four dimensions of education: 21st century teaching & learning

Fadel’s four dimensions include knowledge, skills, character and metacognition.

Andreas Schleicher, Director for Education and Skills, Organization for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) recently wrote that

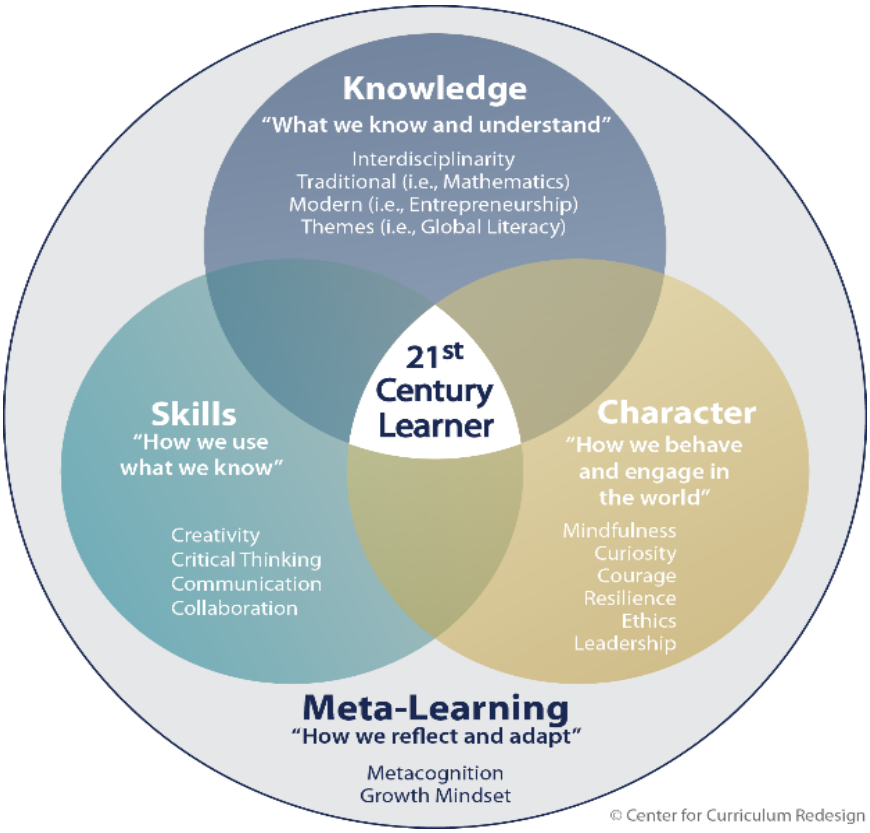
"Today, schools need to prepare students for more rapid economic and social change than ever before, for jobs that have not yet been created, to use technologies that have not yet been invented, and to solve social problems that we don't yet know will arise."

In the knowledge domain, he speaks about the need for young people to become both specialists and generalists, learning a field of study in depth and yet also appreciating and understanding how their specialty connects to other disciplines.

In addition he argues that we must introduce students to interdisciplinary knowledge critical to tackle many of the challenges facing society today. In the sphere of skills, he underscores the significance of four skill categories: *critical thinking, creativity, communication and collaboration*. He also notes the importance of supporting students to utilize these skills to apply their knowledge to new problems.

Finally, Fadel contends that knowledge and skills are not sufficient in today's world. We must support students' character development to ensure that they develop the qualities necessary to contribute to shaping a better world. These include: mindfulness, curiosity, courage, resilience, ethics and leadership.

Fadel notes that to continue to grow and develop and to learn young people need to develop the skills of metacognition. This term refers to the ability and habit of constantly reflecting on oneself as a learner including one's learning goals, strategies and results. Two meta cognitive domain identified by Fadel are: developing a growth mindset, based on the work of Stanford psychologist Carol Dweck and also meta-learning which Fadel sees as the motivation to challenge ourselves to continuously learn when we are no longer compelled by educational institutions. Fadel's powerful synthesis of research into curriculum is summarized in this infographic.



5.3 Assessment questions

1. In your own words, differentiate between the various dimensions of curriculum
2. Explain the meaning of dimension in the concept of learning and education
3. State five activities that describe the informal dimension of curriculum in a school set up
4. Explain why the formal dimension of curriculum is seen as the most prominent among the dimensions of curriculum

5.4 References

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